Kitchen Rush

Game Script

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Course: CSCI 5499B

Due Date: 11/6/2026

GitHub repository: https://github.com/daggerscythe/kitchen-rush

Engine: Unreal Engine 5.8

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1. Game Concept

1.1 Elevator Pitch

Kitchen Rush: Grandma's Watch is a first-person cooking game where time only moves when you move. Run your late grandmother's diner through one Friday dinner rush, from 5 PM to 10 PM, by stopping to read a kitchen full of flying knives and steaks, then moving through it to cook, throw, catch, and serve. Survive the night and earn enough tips to pay the rent.

1.2 Concept Description

Orders show up as tickets above the pass window, each with a green patience bar that shrinks as time passes. You grab ingredients from the crates, chop them, cook steaks and soup on the stove, plate them, and serve the dish before the bar runs out. The catch is the time rule: world time follows your movement. While you walk, everything runs at normal speed. When you stand still, the whole kitchen (cook meters, patience bars, flying knives, and even the shift clock) slows to a crawl, so you can look around for free and plan. Every action such as a chop, a pick-up, or a throw also costs a short burst of time, and food only cooks while time is moving, so sometimes the right play is to pace in place until a steak is done.

You can throw any ingredient, plate, or even the frying pan, and catch what Gus the waiter tosses. As the night goes on, tickets pile up, a soup pot opens, Gus trips and sends knives and hot sauce flying, a shelf collapses, and a final chain reaction forces you to use your skills in a way the game never showed you.

1.3 Connection to the Theme

The theme is **Time**, and time is the game's resource, its main mechanic, and its input. Every step, chop, and throw advances the clock, the cook meters, the patience bars, and the hazards, so planning your route is the same as spending time. Standing still buys thinking time. The setting is also about time: a shift clock from 5 PM to 10 PM, an inherited pocket watch that is the game's logo and speed gauge, a watch tick you can hear slow down and stop, and Nana's tutorial notes like "Time waits for a cook who stops to think."

1.4 Expected Player & Player Experience Goals

Following player-centric design, my representative player is 18 to 25, comfortable with WASD and mouse-look from first-person games, and likes puzzles or casual cooking games like *Overcooked*. They do not need to know *Superhot*. Using VandenBerghe's Five Domains of Play, they are medium-high on Challenge (patience bars, strikes, perfect windows), medium-high on Novelty (the time rule is unusual for a cooking game), low on Stimulation (solo play), and low-medium on Threat (hazards hurt but the tone is warm, never scary).

The player should feel calm in the middle of chaos: panic a little when Gus yells "Watch out!", then stop, breathe, look, and feel clever when a plan works, such as catching a steak straight into the pan. They should also want one more night for a better tip total. I did run into the "I am my own typical player" trap: things that were obvious to me, like catching the onion in the Act 2 lesson, soft-locked some testers, and a lot of the playtest changes came from that.

2. Genre

Primary genres: **Simulation** (3D, first-person cooking and time management) and **Puzzle**, mixed with **Action and Arcade** physics hazards. It combines the order-fulfillment style of *Overcooked* with the "time moves when you move" rule of *Superhot*. There are no enemies, because the resource and the threat are the same thing: time.

3. Background Information

3.1 Story & Setting

You inherited your grandmother's diner, **The Second Hand**, and it owes three months of rent. Tonight is the town's Friday dinner rush, your one shot to earn enough in tips to keep the doors open. Nana left you one more thing: her brass pocket watch. Wind it, and the world holds its breath while you stand still. Nana ran this kitchen alone for forty years, and now you know how. Her handwritten notes are still taped around the kitchen, and they are the tutorial. Gus, the diner's loyal but clumsy waiter, shouts orders through the pass and causes most of the night's disasters. At closing, the tips jar is counted against the rent: surviving the night saves the diner (1 star), and a great night means Nana would be proud (2 to 3 stars).

3.2 Real-World Background

The game is based on how a real restaurant kitchen works: order tickets hang on a rail above the pass, and cooks work from stations (crates, chopping boards, stove, plates). Real line cooks call the habit of stopping to look before acting "working clean", and that is the real-world idea the game is built around. The idea that time moves only when the player moves comes from the game *Superhot*.

3.3 What the Player Needs to Know Before Playing

- The game opens on a **main menu** (Play, Continue, Settings, Quit). Click in the window to play, and press **Esc** to pause. Nana's notes pop up on screen with a **Got it** button and a **Skip tutorial** button.
- Keyboard and mouse only, and sound on is recommended: the pocket-watch tick shows how fast time is moving, and Gus shouts "Heads up!" and "Watch out!" before anything flies.
- Your settings, high score, and the last act you reached are saved, so **Continue** restarts from that act. The game does not use the network.
- The game is for Windows (x86). Download the v1.0 Windows release from GitHub and run the game's .exe. A night takes about 10 minutes.

4. What the Game Teaches

4.1 Learning Goals

Kitchen Rush turns a chaotic dinner rush into a lesson that time is a budget you spend with every action, so planning before moving beats rushing. It teaches:

- **Time follows movement:** walking, chopping, and throwing advance the world, and standing still freezes it.

- **Plan, then execute:** stop, scan the kitchen, pick a route, then move with purpose.
- **Economy of motion:** shorter routes and fewer wasted steps mean less time passes, so food burns less and customers wait less.
- **Moving on purpose to make time pass:** food only cooks while you move, so sometimes the right play is to pace in place.
- **Prioritizing:** with 2 or 3 tickets and hazards at once, you decide which order, meter, or danger comes first.
- **Reading a frozen scene:** flying hazards are puzzles: what will hit me, what can I catch, and where do I step?

The real-world takeaway is the line cook's "stop, look, then act" habit: calm planning is faster than panic. In terms of Gardner's intelligences from *Theory of Fun*, the game mostly uses **Spatial** (reading a frozen 3D scene and planning a route), **Logical-mathematical** (recipes, timing windows, and scoring), and **Bodily-kinesthetic** (aiming throws and catches).

4.2 How Each Concept Is Taught

Concept	Where	How the player is taught
Time follows movement	Act 1, step 1	The kitchen starts frozen. Nana's note says to take a step: the clock, the watch tick, and the cook meters only move while you do, and everything freezes again when you stop.
Crates, chopping, plating, serving, the trash	Act 1, Tomato Salad	A tomato from the crate, chopped with E four times ("Even a knife costs time"), plated, and served at the pass. There is no patience bar yet, and the note mentions the trash bin.
Cook meters, burning, patience	Act 1, Steak	"Food only cooks while you move. Pace if you must." Overcook it and a small flare teaches burning, and a free retry steak appears. The patience bar appears for the first time, set very generous.
Planning while frozen	Act 1, Garden Salad	Two chops and a plate with patience on. "Plan the route while the world waits."
Throwing	Act 2, "Toss it, don't walk it"	You must throw a steak into the pan to continue. A thrown item lands where pressing E would have put it.
Catching	Act 2, "Heads up!"	About a second after the steak starts cooking, Gus tosses an onion: "Look at it and press E." Catching it (or picking it up after it lands) starts the rush with a Steak and Onions ticket.
Dodging and reading a frozen scene	Act 2, Gus's first trip (6:00 PM)	Time auto-freezes at the peak of the trip with the note "Breathe. Look." The player dodges the knives and catches the steaks onto a plate or into the pan.
Prioritizing	Act 2, the rush	Two or three tickets at once, plus Gus tossing requested ingredients (Gus Assist bonus).

Concept	Where	How the player is taught
Soup and the pot	Act 2, 5:30 PM	The pot opens with a Tomato Soup ticket straight away. Its meter shows when to ladle, like the pan.
Throwing as a tool	Act 3, chain reaction	"Can't get there? Make something get there." The pan is thrown to knock the pot off the burner.
Precise time control	Act 3, pacing puzzle	No note on purpose: the player works out the micro-bursts of movement needed to land two meters in their windows.
Catch and dodge together	Act 3, shelf collapse	Tomatoes and knives rain down. The player catches tomatoes onto a held plate while dodging knives.

5. Core Mechanics & How to Play

5.1 Controls

Input	Action
W / A / S / D	Move (makes time flow)
Mouse	Look (free: looking never makes time move)
E	Interact: pick up, place, chop, serve, ladle, take food from the pan, catch an airborne item
Left mouse (hold)	Show the throw arc
Left mouse (release)	Throw the held item
Left Ctrl (hold)	Crouch: lower camera, half walk speed (crouch-walking still moves time)
Esc	Pause menu
Mouse click	Got it / Skip tutorial buttons on Nana's note pop-ups, and all menu buttons

5.2 Core Mechanics

Time follows movement
World time slows to 0.05x while you stand still and runs at normal speed while you walk. It ramps smoothly so it never snaps: speeding up takes 1.5 seconds and slowing down takes 1 second. Looking around is always free. An action (a chop, pick-up, place, throw, or catch) plays a short 0.3 second burst of normal time even if you are standing still. Cook meters, patience bars, hazards, thrown items, health regeneration, and the shift clock all run on world time, but you always move at your own normal speed. While time is slow the screen goes slightly desaturated and blue, the watch tick slows to a stop, and the kitchen sounds sink low and muffled.

Cooking and stations
Take one ingredient (tomato, lettuce, onion, or steak) from a crate on the back wall. Chop it on a board with four presses of E. Put a steak in the pan, where a meter above it shows raw, perfect, and burnt zones, or put two chopped tomatoes in the pot to make soup. Plates and bowls come from the rack on the center island, and the finished plate goes under its ticket at the pass. The trash bin clears a plate or pan. Hands hold one thing at a time, including the pan or pot.

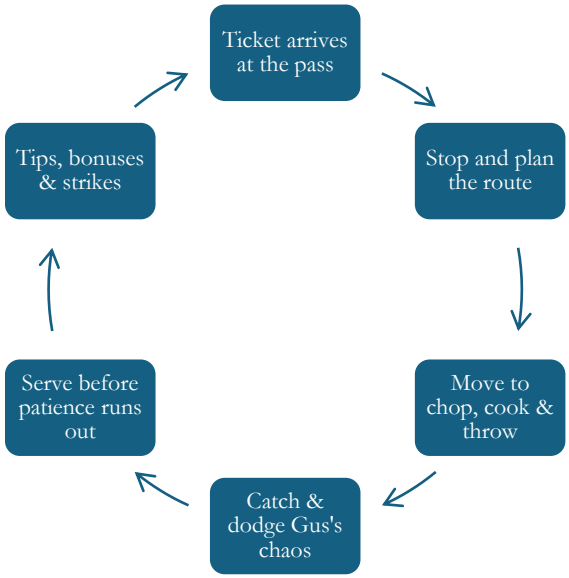
Throwing and catching
Hold the left mouse button to show the arc and release to throw. A thrown item that lands on a plate, in the pan or pot, on an empty chopping board, or in the bin counts as placed, and a plate thrown through the pass window is served. Anything else lands on the floor. To catch, look at an airborne item within 3 meters and press E: it snaps to your hands, or onto your plate if you are holding one. Knives cannot be caught, and trying costs health.

Orders and tips
Tickets show the dish icon, its parts, and a green patience bar. Serving a dish earns its price times how correct it was, plus bonuses for perfect cooking, trick shots, catching Gus's tosses, and serving quickly, minus a penalty for food that touched the floor. Every served order shows as a receipt that slides in on the left side of the screen, one line at a time.

Gus and hazards
Gus rings the bell for new orders and causes the night's disasters. He always warns first. When he trips, his tray explodes into steaks, knives, and a hot sauce bottle flying across the kitchen. Burning a steak starts a grease fire, leaving soup on the pot too long makes it boil over, and a plate or bowl that hits the floor fast shatters into pieces that hurt to step on.

Health, strikes, and the clock
You have 100 health, which regenerates after a few seconds of world time without damage, so you have to move to heal. A customer who runs out of patience walks out for a strike, and so does a dish that is less than 20% correct. Zero health or three strikes ends the night early. The shift clock runs from 5:00 PM to 10:00 PM on world time.

5.3 Core Gameplay Loop



The whole game is this loop, with Gus interrupting every step. It gets harder as tickets pile up, new stations open, and the hazards get bigger.

6. Game Modes

Kitchen Rush has the following game modes (according to Adams):

- **Primary gameplay mode, The Friday Night (Plan & Serve):** first-person, dynamic camera, avatar-based interaction. All actions are available (move, look, crouch, interact, throw, catch). The UI is the full HUD: health bar (top-left), tips and strikes (top-right), shift clock (top-center), pocket-watch speed icon (bottom-right), order tickets with patience bars (right side), held item and plate contents (bottom-center), a crosshair with a context prompt, the throw arc, floating cook meters, and the receipt log (left-center). It covers Act 2 (The Dinner Rush) and Act 3 (Closing Time).
- **Tutorial mode (Act 1, Nana's Notes):** same camera and controls, but the clock is frozen at 5:00 PM and the game is task-based: each step unlocks the next. There are no strikes, a wrong dish is handed back, patience refills, and Gus's hazards do not appear. A **Skip tutorial** button on every pop-up jumps straight to the dinner rush.
- **Shell menus (game paused):** the main menu (Play, Continue, Settings, Quit), settings (mouse sensitivity, UI scale, master and music volume), Nana's note pop-ups (Got it, Skip tutorial), the first-trip auto-freeze pop-up, the pause menu (Resume, Settings, Notes, Restart act, Main menu, Quit), and the Results / Game Over screen (tips, stars, high score, Play again, Main menu). The pause menu's **Notes** page lets you flip through every note you have seen this run.
- **Competition mode:** single player against the game system. There is no multiplayer, and the only other competition is the saved high score and star rating.

Moving between modes: main menu (Play) → Act 1 tutorial (Skip tutorial jumps ahead) → Act 2 → Act 3 → Results at 10:00 PM. Esc opens the pause menu from any gameplay mode. Zero health or a third strike jumps to Game Over. Play again restarts the night, and Continue on the main menu reloads the level at the last act you reached.

7. Rules

Following *Rules of Play*, the rules are split into **operational** (what the player is told), **constitutive** (the underlying math), and **implicit** (unwritten) rules. Together they should be enough to play the game without a computer.

7.1 Objective / Win Condition

Survive the shift: the clock runs from 5:00 PM to 10:00 PM, and at 10:00 PM the Results screen shows your tips, stars, and high score. Surviving gives 1 star, tips of $200 or more give 2 stars, and tips of $300 or more give 3 stars.

7.2 Lose / Setback Conditions

- **Health reaches 0** or **3 strikes** ends the night. A strike comes from a customer walking out when their patience bar hits 0, or from serving a dish that is less than 20% correct. There are no strikes in Act 1.
- **Setbacks:** wrong or extra parts lower the tips, a burnt steak counts as a wrong part, food that touched the floor costs $3 each, a timeout gives no tips, and fire, spills, and broken plates hurt.

7.3 Operational Rules

- You hold one thing at a time: an ingredient, a plate or bowl, or the pan or pot. A plate holds up to 3 parts, and the HUD shows its contents.
- Chopping takes 4 presses of E. A steak only cooks while it sits in the pan on a burner and world time is moving. Pull it in the perfect window, and a steak left too long burns and then starts a grease fire.
- Soup needs 2 chopped tomatoes in the pot and is ladled into a bowl by pressing E with an empty bowl. Leave it too long and it boils over.
- To serve, put the finished plate under its ticket at the pass, or throw it through the window. A caught ingredient lands on your plate if you are holding one.
- Hot sauce can be caught safely. Knives cannot be caught, so dodge them. Anything thrown at a pan or pot on a burner knocks it off.
- Pick up a pile of broken plate pieces with E and put it in the trash bin, because stepping on it hurts.
- There is no jump or sprint, and a closed room keeps you inside.

7.4 Constitutive Rules

- **Time:** world time scale is 0.05x while still and 1.0x while walking (speed-up ramp 1.5 s, slow-down ramp 1 s, both smoothed). An action plays a 0.3 s burst at 1.0x with a 0.08 s ramp. The shift clock runs one in-game hour per 60 seconds of world time.
- **Player:** 100 HP, walk speed 4 m/s, and crouching halves it. After 4 seconds of world time without damage, you regain 5 HP per second of world time. You can catch things within 3 meters.
- **Cooking:** the steak is cooked at 8 s, perfect from 8 to 11 s, and burnt at 14 s, then catches fire at 17 s (the fire lasts 10 s and the burner is unusable). Soup is ready at 12 s, perfect if ladled before 18 s, starts to boil over at 18 s, and spills at 24 s.
- **Orders:** a new ticket arrives every 15 seconds while there is room, with at most 1 open ticket in Act 1 and 3 in Acts 2 and 3. Dishes come from a shuffle bag, so every dish on the menu appears once before any repeats. Patience is 12 seconds + 5 seconds per step of the dish (Tomato Salad 22 s, Garden Salad 27 s, Steak and Onions 27 s), and Tomato Soup is 52 s.
- **Correctness:** correct parts divided by required parts, minus 25% per wrong or extra part, with a minimum of 0%. Under 20% gives no tips and a strike.
- **Scoring per dish** (tips in dollars; a dish never earns less than $0):
  - Dish price × correctness: Tomato Salad $8, Garden Salad $12, Steak and Onions $16, Tomato Soup $20
  - +$1 Perfect order (every part right and nothing extra)
  - +$2 Perfect cook (steak pulled in the perfect window, or soup ladled before 18 s)
  - +$1 per trick shot: each ingredient counts once per place it was thrown into (chopping board, plate, pan, pot), plus 1 if the plate or bowl was thrown through the pass
  - +$2 per Gus Assist (an ingredient Gus tossed, caught in mid-air, served in the dish and never touched the ground)
  - +$3 Patience bonus (the ticket's patience bar is at least 70% full when served)
  - -$3 for each served ingredient that ever touched the floor
  - +$1 for each knife that passes within 1 meter without hitting you (hazard dodged)
- **Hazards:** all damage values and timings live in one tuning data asset.

Hazard	Source	Effect	Counter
Flying knife	Gus trips, shelf collapse	40 damage on hit (20 if you try to catch it), then it sticks in the wall	Freeze and step out of its line
Hot sauce bottle	Gus trips	Shatters on impact, 20 damage within 1.5 m	Dodge it, or catch it before it lands
Grease fire	Steak left 3 s past burnt	Fire on the burner for 10 s, 30 damage per second within 1 m	Pull the steak before it burns
Boil-over	Soup left past 24 s	Scalding spill for 8 s, 20 damage per second, soup ruined	Take the pot off, or knock it off with a throw
Broken plate or bowl	A plate or bowl hits the floor fast	Pieces stay on the floor, 10 damage per step	Pick the pile up and bin it
Flying ingredients	Gus trips or tosses	Harmless, but lost or penalized if they hit the floor	Catch them, ideally onto a plate

- **Gus:** a trip shows a big HUD warning (and an arrow if he is behind you) 2.5 s of world time before anything flies. A trip launches a steak, knife, hot sauce bottle, steak, knife, and knife in that order. Outside scripted beats he trips every 25 s. He tosses an ingredient only when a new ticket arrives (a 25% chance), with a 1.5 s HUD message first.

Act	Clock	World time	Tickets	Menu	What is new
1	5:00 PM (frozen)	Not timed	1	Tomato Salad, Steak, Garden Salad	The time rule, stations, and cook meters
2	5:00 to 7:30 PM	100 s (clock runs 1.5x)	3	Salads, Steak and Onions, Tomato Soup from 5:30	Throw, catch, Gus tosses, trips at 6:00 and 6:30, pot opens
3	7:30 to 10:00 PM	150 s	3	All four dishes	Shelf at 8:00, chain reaction around 8:30, Nana's Special at 9:40

Real time is longer than world time, because players stop to think while time is slow. Pausing and pop-ups stop the clock.

7.5 Implicit Rules

- **Gus always warns first:** every flying hazard is announced before it launches, so a hit is always the player's fault.
- **Stay in the kitchen:** there are solid walls on every side, no door to walk through, and a kill volume that respawns you at the pass if you ever fall out.
- **Customers are never shown:** a customer who loses patience just leaves.
- **One night, one sitting:** the only things saved are settings, high score, and the last act reached for Continue.

8. Level Design & Progression

8.1 Level Overview

The game is one continuous level in one closed kitchen: ingredient crates on the back wall, the stove on the left wall, two chopping boards on the right wall, the plate rack and trash bin on a center island, and the pass window on the front wall. Every station is 2 to 3 seconds of walking away, so routes matter but don't feel like filler. The level has three acts: **Act 1 (Nana's Notes)** teaches every basic in a safe order, **Act 2 (The Dinner Rush)** adds throwing, catching, and dodging under pressure, and **Act 3 (Closing Time)** asks the player to use each skill in a way they were never shown.

8.2 Using the Concepts in New Ways

- **Throw becomes a tool:** in Act 2 you throw a steak into the pan to save steps. In Act 3, the chain reaction puts you across the room behind flying knives while the soup is about to boil over, and the only fix is to throw something at the pot to knock it off the burner.
- **Stop-and-go becomes precise control:** in Act 1 time just stops and starts. In Act 3 a steak needs 3 more seconds while the soup is close to boiling over, so the player moves in tiny bursts to land both meters in their windows.
- **Catch and dodge happen at the same time:** in Act 2 you catch and dodge in separate steps. In Act 3, the shelf collapse rains tomatoes and knives together, so you catch tomatoes onto a held plate while dodging knives.
- **Prioritizing becomes one combined order:** Act 2 gives you two or three tickets. Nana's Special at 9:40 PM is two tickets at once (Steak and Onions plus Tomato Soup), using every station at once.

8.3 Difficulty Curve & Playtime

Difficulty follows the clock: Act 1 is forgiving with generous patience and no strikes. Act 2 adds up to 3 tickets and the first trips, and Act 3 adds the pot, the shelf, and the chain reaction. Patience and ticket speed were tightened in playtesting because players can stop time so often. The game is designed to take about **10 minutes** of real time: Act 1 about 3 minutes, Act 2 about 2.5 minutes, and Act 3 about 3.5 minutes. Each act is split into short beats so no part is filler.

9. Art, Animation & Audio

9.1 Visual Style

The look is cutesy low-poly with hard, faceted edges and flat colors, with no textures: each colored part is its own material in a shared palette (cream and mint walls, a cherry-red and teal kitchen, a checkered floor). The 49 3D models (kitchen shell, stations, food, hazards, VFX, and Gus), the UI icons (ingredients, dishes, tickets, strikes, stars, pocket watch, note card), and the logo were generated by Claude as one asset pack so everything matches. The steak changes color with its cook state, and when time slows the screen desaturates with a slight blue tint. The UI uses the Fredoka font and Nana's notes use the Caveat handwriting font.

9.2 Animations

There are no skeletal character animations. All motion comes from code and physics: trash lid swings open when you look at the bin holding something, the pocket-watch hand turns with the time scale, patience and cook meters fill, receipt lines slide in from the left.

9.3 Audio

The audio rule is **you are outside time, the world is not**: sounds the world makes (kitchen, hazards, music) bend with time, and sounds you make (footsteps, throws, the watch, the UI) do not. When time slows, world sounds drop in pitch and are muffled like hearing them underwater, but loops such as the sizzle and bubbling keep playing. The pocket-watch tick plays once per second of world time, so it is steady while you walk, spreads out as you slow down, and stops when time is frozen. A tape-stop sweep plays when time drops and a spin-up whoosh plays when it returns. The diner jukebox music is never pitched (slowed music drifts out of key) and only gets quieter and muffled. Gus's shouts are not bent, so a warning is always understood. In total 39 sound files fill 37 slots in one audio data asset.

Events	Source
"Heads up!" and "Watch out!" (Gus)	Recorded by Joey Carlisle
UI click	Recorded by me
Pocket-watch tick and tock, diner murmur, win and game over sounds, cooking (chop, sizzle, pot, fire, ding, dish clink, trash, plop), hazards (knife, plate break, shelf, splat), throws and landings (pan clang, pot clang, thud, throw whoosh), player (heartbeat, hurt), orders (new order bell, order served, note rustle)	Pixabay
Footsteps	Uppbeat.io
Jukebox music	StockTune
Tape-stop, spin-up	SampleFocus

No copyrighted material is used. Master and Music volume are set with sliders in the settings menu.

10. Iterations & Playtesting

10.1 Playtesting Process

I play-tested every milestone myself while building (Oct 27 to Oct 30), then had other players try the game Nov 2 – 4. After each session I wrote down what confused people and what they asked for in a running playtest-notes file, and ranked it into the next set of changes. The two time-rule variants (Freeze or Slow when still, Clamped or Momentum when walking) were both built into the Settings menu so testers could compare them.

10.2 Iteration Log

Commit	What changed	Why (playtest feedback / reasoning)
2871cd8	Time ramps slowed: 0.8 s speed up, 0.35 s slow down, 0.08 s action bursts; still mode set to Slow	Time felt like it changed instantly, but it should build up like in *Superhot*
	Crouch added (hold Left Ctrl), with the camera lowered smoothly	Requested while testing the kitchen
	Stove uses two collision boxes, and ticket text wraps	Pans sat raised on the burners, and long dish names overflowed the tickets
bd5420a	All UI scaled up (Application Scale 1.4)	All UI elements were too small to read
	Hazard damage tripled, then set halfway	First, hazards did not hurt enough; after tripling they were too punishing
	Gus trips more often, with a big pulsing warning and an arrow when he is behind you; tosses use a plain message; trip warning shortened	Trips were too rare and the warning came too late to turn around, but tosses are harmless and did not need an alarm
	Orders dealt from a shuffle bag	Garden Salad came up 4 times in a row
	A plate thrown through the pass window is served	Requested as another use of throwing
	Gus Assist bonus, and -$3 for food that touched the floor	Catching Gus's tosses should pay, and dropped food should cost money
	Scoring reworked with dish prices, a perfect order bonus, a flat patience bonus, and a slide-in receipt log	Requested receipt format, the same way *Twick o Tweat* showed completed orders, which a playtester liked
d71c21f	Act director with notes, menus, and a Skip tutorial button on every pop-up	On a second play-through, closing every tutorial pop-up again was tedious (from *Twick o Tweat*)
01c6d77	Patience cut from 30 + 10 per step to 20 + 7	Order timers were too long, since you can stop time so often
	Trip warning shortened from 1.5 s to 1.2 s	Gus should throw his hazards a little sooner after the warning
	The first Act 2 ticket after the lesson is always Steak and Onions	The lesson's ingredients should go straight into an order
234775	Act 2 shortened from 150 s to 100 s of world time	The dinner rush was too long
43a3ffd	Pot opens at 5:30 PM in Act 2 with a soup ticket right away; the intro tomato in Act 1 removed	The time before the pot felt like filler, and the tomato was unnecessary
43a3ffd	Gus tosses only when a new ticket arrives (25% chance, one of that dish's ingredients)	Tosses should be relevant to the orders, and "Heads up!" was said too often
	Patience cut to 12 + 5 per step, a ticket every 15 s, and 3 tickets in Act 2	It was too easy without slowing time, and players should have to plan every move
	Trips at 6:00 and 6:30 PM and then every 25 s; the shelf collapse moved to 8:00 PM	The shelf collapsed only once and very late, and hazards should start earlier to make it hectic
	Trip warning lengthened to 2.5 s; speed-up ramp lengthened to 1.5 s	There was no time to stop for the knives, and time sped up too fast

Commit	What changed	Why (playtest feedback / reasoning)
	Throw arc drawn with a line trace; the pan is picked up together with its steak	The arc dots did not show for ingredients, and moving the pan and steak took two steps
	Loose items no longer block the player	A thrown lettuce carried a player across the map, and broken plate pieces flung another
	Act 2 lesson reordered: throw the steak first, then Gus tosses the onion	Catching the onion sometimes soft-locked the game
	Pause menu Notes page with < > arrows	Players wanted to re-read Nana's notes
f8f08f7	Slowdown delay removed; time now starts slowing at once and settles over 1 s	The wait before time slowed felt too long, even as a slider
	Looking at the steak takes only the steak, and the rim or handle takes the pan	Picking up just the cooked steak still did not work
05c2b86	Time modes locked to Slow when still and normal speed when walking; toggles removed	Final decision after both variants were tested
	A placed pan turns its handle to the player's left	The handle hit the backsplash and knocked the pan off the burner
	Act 2 onion lesson accepts any onion, with timeouts as safety nets	One tester soft-locked the lesson twice in a row
	Tomato Soup patience raised to 52 s; trip order set to steak, knife, hot sauce, steak, knife, knife	Soup needed more patience, and the trip should be a fixed, readable pattern
	Shelf knives launch 60 cm out from the shelf	One knife got stuck in the shelf and never flew

10.3 Key Design Changes

The time rule was A/B tested, then locked. I did not know whether standing still should freeze or just slow time, or whether walking should speed up over time or stay at normal speed, so both options were in the Settings. After testing, standing still is Slow and walking is normal speed. A 1 second wait before slowing was tried and then removed, because players found it too long, and it is replaced by a short ramp so time still eases down.

Orders got tighter because players can stop time. Play-testing showed that players had so much thinking time that the game was easy, so patience went from 30 + 10 per step to 20 + 7 and then to 12 + 5, and tickets arrive every 15 seconds. The goal is that players have to plan every move and what it costs, which is the lesson of the game.

Hazards moved from too weak, to too strong, to fair. Tripling the damage made hazards too punishing, so I settled halfway, and Gus's trip warning grew to 2.5 seconds so a player can stop and let time slow before knives arrive. Hazards also start earlier (6:00 PM) and repeat more often, so the second half of the night is hectic.

Scoring rewards the game actions. Trick shots count per ingredient and place, Gus Assist pays for catches, and food that touches the floor costs $3, so throwing, catching, and careful carrying all show up in the receipt log on the left.

Tutorial soft-locks were fixed by making the lesson forgiving. The Act 2 onion lesson originally needed a catch. Testers got stuck when the onion landed first, or when they picked up a

different onion. The lesson now throws the steak first, accepts any onion, and has timeouts, so nobody gets stuck.

11. Credits & Assets

The 49 low-poly 3D models, the UI icons, and the logo were generated by Claude. Gus's voice lines were recorded by Joey Carlisle, and the UI click was recorded by me. Sound effects and music are from free libraries (Pixabay, SampleFocus, StockTune, Uppbeat.io). The Fredoka and Caveat fonts are used under the SIL Open Font License. Made in Unreal Engine 5.8.

12. Future Work

- **Freeplay mode** after beating the night, with random orders and random Gus events, no end, and difficulty that ramps up with tips.
- **Real animations:** a walking, tripping Gus, and customers at the pass window who react to their food.
- **More dishes, stations, and levels:** an oven, new recipes (kept in a data table so no code is needed), and new kitchens that twist the time rule in new ways.
- **Settings:** key rebinding, controller support, and separate sound effect and voice volume.